England teammates had a 360-degree view of my career. They saw me as a bloke at rock bottom and fearing for his future in 2010, as a fighter scoring 766 in an Ashes series in Australia the following winter, and as the authority figure going through the fires of captaincy and controversy in 2014. It is an individual trial, but a collective experience.

Together, you experience the highs of winning and the dreadful lows of losing a tight game. You are strapped into the same emotional roller coaster and can relate to one another. I'm drawn to the exclusivity of the process. No one else is allowed into the inner sanctum, where you must be true to yourself and those around you.

With trust comes understanding. Steven Davies and I go back to that Under-19 World Cup, yet I was unaware of his deepest secret until a telephone call from Andrew Strauss and Andy Flower before the 2010–11 Ashes tour. Steve, selected as understudy to Matt Prior, wanted us to know of his homosexuality and, as a group, we pledged to keep it in-house until he wished to make an announcement.

I found his air of liberation, when he came out in February 2011, deeply affecting. The barriers were down on that tour, when he felt free to share the isolation he had felt previously. He had been in the T20 group for two years and would retreat to his hotel room rather than go out with the lads. The frustration of being too inhibited to be himself was profound.

He spoke of being sick with nerves in our pre-tour get-together at Lord's, where, like the rest of the group, I made a point of offering my support. He was Steve, the cricketer. Nothing more, nothing less. Professional sport is a pressure chamber at the best of times and for him to carve an international career when enduring such internal turmoil is a convincing summary of character.

Acceptance was instant, universal and enduring, once he made his announcement. That's as it should be. Straussy and Andy deserved a great deal of credit for their approach, which combined empathy with practicality. On a professional level, they saw it as an issue to be dealt with and filed away for future reference, when required. On a personal level, they related to the humanity of Steve's dilemma.

We all need a helping hand, in various ways. Mine, in a cricketing sense, came consistently from Graham Gooch. His 333 against India in July 1990, a ten-and-a-half-hour marathon that would be voted as the greatest innings seen at Lord's, was my first conscious sporting memory. I was five at the